Cover photo from the original story

From curiosity to cash crop

Madurankuliya - Puttalam

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Passion is hard to hide. It will manifest as a glint in the eye or as a hop in the step. It’s impossible not to see how passionate Manoj is about farming. He walks about his simple homestead with the pride and conviction of a man with purpose. He has the aura of a man with unique vision and a plight to set himself apart from the average farmer.

Manoj is a 41-year-old family man with two children. He lives off the beaten track in a tucked away corner of the rugged Puttalam district of North-Western Sri Lanka. Manoj lives and farms on a 2-acre plot of land. He has sectioned off a quarter of an acre where he tries and tests new fertilizers, pesticides, and farming techniques.

> **“People in the area know me for growing crops, no one else could grow. I am proud to say that I managed to control and be rid of the fall army worm before anyone else.”**

The virtue of curiosity

Manoj is well-known in the district as an unorthodox farmer - his call to fame being the taming of the fall army worm. He regales the story of how he farmed 10 acres of maize. He is given credit in the locality for having discovered that Maize seeds that were imported with the larva of the fall army worm.

He refuses to disclose his exact methods which he used to get rid of the fall army worm, but says he used to spray at least 60 cans of pesticide on this crop and wished that he had been aware of a system like this and that it could have saved him a lot of money and effort.

The Japan Supplementary Budget (JSB) funded ‘Enhancing Food and Energy Security through the Promotion of Green Technologies & Renewable Energy for Wider Uptake among Vulnerable Smallholder Farmers in Sri Lanka’ project, focuses on providing immediate crisis relief support to marginalized farmer demographics in the Dry-Zone farmland areas of the country.

Beneficiaries with innovative and trendsetting mindsets like Manoj serve as catalysts to promote wider uptake of new farming techniques in the community and make a clear case for the necessity to move towards clean and renewable energy sources.

> *“I started this small plot as an experiment, not to make money from it. I wanted to grow at least 10 vegetables without using pesticides for my children and family.”*

Sceptic to believer

Manoj is open about his initial scepticism regarding the solar powered moth repellent technology that was introduced through the project. The heavy-handed use of extremely strong pesticides is the only way Manoj has ever known to grow crops such as eggplant, cabbage, tomato, beetroot, and radish.

> *“It’s been 4 months now since I started using the light system, and the results are amazing. I haven’t had to spray pesticides at all. And I haven’t found a single worm in my crops.”*

Manoj insists that it is impossible to grow cabbage, eggplant, or any of the crops he’s growing without pesticides and claims the solar-powered moth repellent is nothing short of a miracle.

An ambassador for innovation

For the moment, Manoj is the only farmer in the Puttalam district with this technology. But he is already receiving inquiries about it from farmers in his community and the district and believes that in the near future it will turn out to be a popular alternative to pesticides. Since the economic crisis in Sri Lanka, the cost of pesticides has increased drastically.

According to Manoj, he now saves close to 24,000 rupees every month by using the solar-powered moth repellent; this money which he uses for his children’s education and healthcare.

“Ironically, the rainy season is the worst time for farmers when it comes to pests - but these lights have proved to me that they are 100% capable of keeping my crops pest-free.”

UNDP with the support of JSB funded project provided Manoj a solar powered moth repellent worth over 2000 USD. This system is powered by an off grid 550W solar panel with 12kWh battery storage. The system includes 9 blinking yellow LED lights which repels nocturnal insects and prevents these insects from laying eggs on crops. This system of 9 LEDs provides coverage for an area of 0.25 acres and requires very low energy input.

“Being able to grow these crops without pesticides is quite a badge of honour for me.”

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